

"Everyone is telling me there will be a different kind of pressure that I have never experienced before. I feel I am well prepared for it. I want to give my best to make some big upsets"

— SREEJA AKULA

AP

Among the many wonders of Hyderabad is the Charminar, a monument that gets its name from its four minarets. It is, thus, befitting that four wonder sportswomen in India's Paris contingent are from this historical city: two-time Olympic medallist P.V. Sindhu, world champion boxer Nikhat Zareen, shooting prodigy Esha Singh and the nation's highest ranked paddler (World No. 25) Sreeja Akula. What is it in the city's air that's made it a nursery for sporting talent? Sreeja gives the credit to its many academies including the Global Table Tennis Academy of Somnath Ghosh, her coach of 14 years. On her last day in the city before she jets off to Germany for a national camp and eventually Paris, Sreeja talks of the relief knowing that Ghosh will join her in what's to be a significant journey. "The confidence I carry when he is there is another level," she says. "We share a good bond. He's like an elder brother. I wouldn't have reached this level without him."

The level in question here has seen Sreeja peak at the opportune time. She began 2024 on a winning note claiming the WTT Feeder Corpus Christi singles title in Texas, before adding another title in Beirut. Then came one of the career-defining moments in June when she became the first Indian paddler to win a WTT Contender singles title in Lagos. Along with that, she also clinched the doubles title with Paris-bound teammate Archana Kamath. "It's a confidence-booster just before the Olympics. I should maintain this [form] in Paris," she says. In her Olympics debut, she is aware the stakes are higher. "Everyone is telling me there'll be a different kind of pressure that I have never experienced before," she says. "I feel I am well prepared for it. I want to give my best to make some big upsets there." She already has one major upset to show off this year, defeating then World No. 2 Chinese paddler Wang Yidi at the World Team Championships.

"Earlier there was this belief that a win against China is impossible," she says. "But other nations are developing fast. They believe anything can happen on a given day...." India is one of them. For the first time, it has five women in the top 100, with Sreeja and Paris teammate Manika Batra ranked under 30. On her part, Sreeja has been fine-tuning her attacking game, working on her forehand and using the topspin to land winners and take the opponent by surprise. Now, to see what aces she has up her sleeve for Paris. ■

–Suhani Singh

INDIA@PARIS 2024

TOPSPIN WHIZ

SREEJA AKULA, 25

Sport: *TABLE TENNIS*
Individual and Women's Team

Achievement: Became the first Indian paddler to win a World Table Tennis Contender singles title in Lagos in June

How she qualified: On the basis of individual and team world rankings